AQA GCSE English Language Paper 1: Explorations in Creative Reading and Writing

These notes are for you, Dougie. They cover every question on Paper 1 of AQA GCSE English Language (8700): what each question asks, how it's marked, how to answer it, and the mistakes that cost people marks. Everything about marks, assessment objectives and mark scheme levels comes from the AQA specification and the AQA Paper 1 specimen mark scheme. Anything that isn't an AQA rule, like timings, is labelled as a suggestion.

The paper at a glance

- Written exam: **1 hour 45 minutes**.
- **80 marks** in total.
- Worth **50% of your GCSE**.
- **Section A: Reading** (40 marks, 25% of your GCSE). You read **one literature fiction text**. It's prose fiction from the 20th or 21st century, taken from a novel or a short story. You won't have seen it before: all texts in the exam are unseen.
- **Section B: Writing** (40 marks, 25% of your GCSE). You do **descriptive or narrative writing**. The task is linked to the topic of the reading text, and you get a choice (AQA says this can be a scenario, a written prompt or a picture).

Question	What it tests	Marks	Assessment objective	Suggested time (a suggestion, not an AQA rule)
Reading the source	Getting to know the extract	None	None	About 15 minutes
1	Finding information	4	AO1	About 5 minutes
2	Language	8	AO2	About 10 minutes
3	Structure	8	AO2	About 10 minutes
4	Evaluation	20	AO4	About 20 minutes
5	Descriptive or narrative writing	40 (24 for content and organisation, 16 for technical accuracy)	AO5 and AO6	About 45 minutes (5 planning, 35 writing, 5 checking)

The assessment objectives on this paper

AQA says the paper tests these in order: AO1, AO2 and AO4 for reading, then AO5 and AO6 for writing.

AO	AQA wording	In plain words

AO1	Identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas. Select and synthesise evidence from different texts.	Find things the text tells you (explicit) and things it hints at (implicit). On Paper 1, Question 1 tests the first part of this.
AO2	Explain, comment on and analyse how writers use language and structure to achieve effects and influence readers, using relevant subject terminology to support their views.	Explain how the writer's words (Question 2) and the way the text is built (Question 3) affect the reader, using the right technical terms.
AO4	Evaluate texts critically and support this with appropriate textual references.	Judge how well the writer has done something, and back up your view with quotations (Question 4).
AO5	Communicate clearly, effectively and imaginatively, selecting and adapting tone, style and register for different forms, purposes and audiences. Organise information and ideas, using structural and grammatical features to support coherence and cohesion of texts.	Write well and imaginatively for the reader and the task, and organise your writing so it hangs together (Question 5, content and organisation).
AO6	Candidates must use a range of vocabulary and sentence structures for clarity, purpose and effect, with accurate spelling and punctuation.	Use a range of words and sentence types, and get your spelling and punctuation right (Question 5, technical accuracy).

How the levels work (Questions 2 to 5)

Questions 2, 3, 4 and 5 are marked in levels. The examiner starts at the lowest level and works up, like climbing a ladder, until they find the level that matches your answer. Then they pick a mark inside that level. To get the **top** mark in a level, your answer needs to do everything that level describes. A mark at the **bottom** of a level means you've done everything in the level below and at least one thing from this level. An answer with nothing relevant to the question gets no marks.

The mark scheme also says you don't need to know technical terms beyond the ones in the specification, but examiners do notice when you use terms well to make your point clearer and more precise.

1.1 Question 1: Listing information

What the question asks

Question 1 is the shortest question on the paper. In the AQA specimen it's worded like this:

> **The question pattern**
> Read again the first part of the source from lines 1 to [a line number].
> List four things from this part of the text about [a topic].

- **Marks:** 4 (one mark for each correct point).
- **Assessment objective:** AO1, the first part: identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas.
- **What to do:** write down four separate things that are true about the topic, taken only from the lines the question gives you. You don't need to analyse anything or name any techniques.
- **Suggested timing (a suggestion, not an AQA rule):** about 5 minutes.

How it's marked

Question 1 doesn't use levels. You get 1 mark for each correct point, up to 4. The specimen mark scheme sets these rules:

Rule from the mark scheme	What it means for you
Answers must be true and drawn only from the lines given.	If the question says lines 1 to 5, a detail from line 6 gets no mark, even if it's true.
Answers must relate to the topic in the question.	If the question is about the weather, a point about a character's coat gets no mark.
You may quote or paraphrase.	You can copy a short phrase from the text, or put the point in your own words. Both are fine.
An own-words answer that covers more than one point gets credit for each point.	This is allowed, but it's safer to write one clear point per line so the examiner can tick each one.
Copying out the whole section word for word gets no marks.	You have to show you picked out the information yourself.

How to do it

Step by step

1. Read the question and underline two things: the **line numbers** and the **topic**.
2. Draw a box around those lines in the source, so your eyes don't wander outside them.
3. Read the boxed lines and underline everything that's about the topic.
4. Pick four **different** points. Two ways of saying the same thing only count once.
5. Write each one as a short, full sentence on its own numbered line.
6. Check each point: is it true, is it inside the lines, is it about the topic?

Terms you need

Term	Meaning
Explicit	Stated plainly in the text. "The road was wet."
Implicit	Hinted at, so you work it out. "Puddles filled the road" tells you it had rained.
Quote	Copy the exact words from the text, in quotation marks.
Paraphrase	Say the same thing in your own words.

Worked example

Practice source

1 By seven o'clock the market was already shouting. Stalls had sprung up
2 overnight along the harbour wall, their striped awnings flapping like
3 loose sails. The smell of frying onions drifted from a van at the far end,
4 and a man with a bucket was sluicing yesterday's fish scales into the
5 gutter. Nobody seemed to notice the drizzle.
6 Ellie pulled her hood up and checked the coins in her pocket for the
7 third time. Her mum had given her exactly enough for bread and a bag of
8 apples, and not a penny for the sweet stall that glittered by the steps.

Question: Read again lines 1 to 5. List four things from this part of the text about the market.

Model answer

1. The market was already noisy by seven o'clock.
2. The stalls were set up along the harbour wall.
3. The stalls had striped awnings that flapped in the wind.
4. You could smell onions frying at a van at the far end.

Why this scores 4 out of 4: every point is true, every point comes from lines 1 to 5, and every point is about the market. Point 1 is implicit: the text says the market was "shouting", and you work out that it was noisy. Each point is on its own line, so the examiner can tick them one by one. Other correct answers would include "the stalls appeared overnight" and "a man was washing fish scales into the gutter". The sweet stall would get **no mark**, because it's on line 8, outside the lines the question gave.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Using the wrong part of the source.** A true detail from outside the line numbers scores nothing. Box the lines before you start.
- **Going off topic.** If the question is about the market, a point about Ellie's coins is wrong. Underline the topic word in the question.
- **Copying out a big chunk.** Copying the whole section gets no marks. Pick out short, separate points.
- **Saying the same thing twice.** "It was noisy" and "it was loud" is one point, not two.

- **Guessing beyond the text.** "The market sold fresh fish" sounds likely, but the text doesn't say it, so it isn't safe. Only write what you can point to.
- **Analysing.** You don't need techniques or effects here. Save that time for Question 4.
- **Writing three, or five.** Only four can score. Write exactly four clear points.

Quick check

▼ **1. How many marks is Question 1 worth, and how are they given?**

4 marks: 1 mark for each correct point.

▼ **2. Which assessment objective does Question 1 test?**

AO1: identify and interpret explicit and implicit information and ideas.

▼ **3. The question says lines 1 to 5. You find a great detail on line 7. Will it score?**

No. Answers must come only from the lines the question gives.

▼ **4. Can you use your own words?**

Yes. You may quote or paraphrase.

▼ **5. What happens if you copy out the whole section word for word?**

You get no marks, because it doesn't show you picked out the information.

1.2 Question 2: Language analysis

What the question asks

In the AQA specimen, Question 2 is worded like this:

> **The question pattern**
> Look in detail at this extract, from lines [x] to [y] of the source.
> How does the writer use language here to describe [a focus]?
> You could include the writer's choice of:
> • words and phrases
> • language features and techniques
> • sentence forms.

- **Marks:** 8.
- **Assessment objective:** AO2: explain, comment on and analyse how writers use language and structure to achieve effects and influence readers, using relevant subject terminology. This question is about the **language** part only: words, phrases, language features, techniques and sentence forms.
- **What to do:** pick out short quotations from the lines given, name what the writer is doing, and explain the effect on the reader, always linked to the focus in the question.
- **Suggested timing (a suggestion, not an AQA rule):** about 10 minutes.

How it's marked

Level and marks	What the mark scheme says	In plain words
Level 4: 7 to 8 marks Detailed, perceptive analysis	Analyses the effects of the writer's choices of language. Selects a judicious range of textual detail. Makes sophisticated and accurate use of subject terminology.	You dig into exactly how words create effects, including things that aren't obvious. Your quotations are short and well chosen. You use technical terms precisely and they help your point.
Level 3: 5 to 6 marks Clear, relevant explanation	Explains clearly the effects of the writer's choices of language. Selects a range of relevant textual detail. Makes clear and accurate use of subject terminology.	You explain clearly what the words do to the reader. You use several relevant quotations. Your terms are correct.
Level 2: 3 to 4 marks Some understanding and comment	Attempts to comment on the effect of language. Selects some appropriate textual detail. Makes some use of subject terminology, mainly appropriately.	You try to say what the words do, but it's not fully explained. You use some suitable quotations and some terms, mostly right.

Level 1: 1 to 2 marks Simple, limited comment	Offers simple comment on the effect of language. Selects simple references or textual details. Makes simple use of subject terminology, not always appropriately.	You make basic comments, pick simple examples, and your terms are sometimes wrong.
Level 0: no marks	No comments offered on the use of language.	Nothing about language.

The specimen mark scheme suggests the sort of thing a good answer might cover: how sentence length links to what's happening, how nouns and verbs build the description, the build-up effect of words and phrases used together, and imagery such as simile.

How to do it

Step by step

1. Underline the **focus** in the question (for example, "to describe the heat"). Every point you make must link back to it.
2. Box the lines you're allowed to use.
3. Read them twice and underline 3 or 4 short quotations: try to get one interesting word, one technique and one sentence form.
4. For each quotation, write a short paragraph:
   - **What** the writer does (name the technique or word class).
   - **Quote** it, keeping it short.
   - **Zoom in** on one word and say what it suggests.
   - **Effect**: what the reader thinks, feels or pictures, and how it links to the focus.
5. Use the words "suggests", "implies", "makes the reader feel", "creates a sense of", and say why.

Terms you need: word classes

Term	What it is	Example
Noun	A thing, person, place or idea	storm, sister, kitchen, fear
Verb	An action or state	crept, shattered, is
Adjective	Describes a noun	heavy, grey, ancient
Adverb	Describes a verb, often ending in "ly"	slowly, fiercely
Pronoun	Stands in for a noun	he, she, it, they, everything

Terms you need: language techniques

Term	What it is	Example
Simile	Compares using "like" or "as"	The fog sat on the town like a wet blanket.

Metaphor	Says something *is* something else	The playground was a battlefield.
Personification	Gives human actions or feelings to something that isn't human	The wind howled at the door.
Pathetic fallacy	Weather or setting that reflects a mood	Rain hammered down on the day of the funeral.
Imagery and sensory language	Words that help you see, hear, smell, taste or feel	the sour tang of smoke
Alliteration	Words close together starting with the same sound	the cold, cruel coast
Sibilance	Repeated "s" or "sh" sounds	the sea's soft, steady hiss
Onomatopoeia	A word that sounds like its meaning	crash, fizz, thud
Repetition	A word or idea used more than once for effect	It was warm. Everything was warm.
Semantic field	A group of words linked to the same topic	"battle", "wounded", "retreat" create a semantic field of war
List	A run of items that builds up an effect	mud, rubble, broken glass and silence
Contrast	Two very different things put close together	the bright lights and the dark alley

Terms you need: sentence forms

Term	What it is	Typical effect
Simple sentence	One main clause	Clear, direct; when short it can shock or slow you down.
Compound sentence	Two main clauses joined by "and", "but", "or", "so"	Links two ideas with equal weight.
Complex sentence	A main clause plus a subordinate clause that can't stand alone	Packs in detail; a long one can feel busy or never-ending.
Minor sentence	A sentence without a main verb	Punchy and sudden: "Silence."
Short sentence	A sentence of a few words	Builds tension or makes a moment stand out.
Long sentence	A sentence that runs on with lots of clauses or a list	Can copy something that goes on and on, like a crowd or a storm.

Question or exclamation	Ends in "?" or "!"	Shows a character's confusion, or strong feeling.

Worked example

Practice extract

The heat arrived before the sun did. By breakfast it had crept into every room of the flat, pressing against the windows and settling on the furniture like a heavy grey dust. Outside, the tarmac softened and sighed. Dogs lay flat in the shade of parked cars, their tongues lolling, too tired even to bark. Mrs Okafor's geraniums, usually so proud on the balcony, drooped their red heads in defeat. Sam pressed a glass of water to his forehead. It was warm. Everything was warm. The whole street seemed to be holding its breath, waiting for a breeze that never came.

Question: How does the writer use language here to describe the heat?

Model answer

The writer presents the heat as an unwelcome visitor that takes over everything. The personification in "crept into every room" makes the heat sound sly, as if it is sneaking in where it isn't wanted, and the verb "pressing" suggests weight and force, so the reader feels how trapped Sam is inside the flat.

The simile "like a heavy grey dust" builds on this. The adjective "heavy" makes the heat feel like something solid you could touch, and "grey" drains the colour out of the morning, so the day feels dull and lifeless before it has even started.

The writer also shows the heat through what it does to living things. The geraniums "drooped their red heads in defeat", which personifies the flowers as if they have lost a fight; the noun "defeat" suggests that nothing can stand up to this heat.

Finally, the short simple sentences "It was warm. Everything was warm." slow the writing right down. The repetition of "warm", and the move from "It" to the pronoun "Everything", make the heat feel as if it has spread everywhere, with no escape, which matches Sam's tired, flat mood.

Why this would score well (Level 4): every paragraph links back to the focus, the heat. The quotations are short and well chosen (a judicious range). It covers all three bullet points: words ("pressing", "defeat"), techniques (personification, simile, repetition) and sentence forms (short simple sentences). The terms are accurate and actually help the explanation. It zooms in on single words and explains what they suggest, and it keeps saying what the reader feels.

Compare a weaker answer: "The writer uses a simile, 'like a heavy grey dust'. This makes it more descriptive and helps you imagine it." This names the technique but the effect could be said about any simile anywhere. It would sit around Level 1 or Level 2.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Feature spotting without effect.** "There is alliteration" scores almost nothing on its own. Always say what the technique does to the reader and how it links to the focus.
- **Retelling the story.** "The heat comes into the flat and the dogs are tired" is just what happens. Talk about the words the writer chose and why.
- **Long quotations.** Copying three lines makes it look as if you don't know which words count. Quote a few words, then zoom in on one.
- **Vague effects.** "It makes it more interesting" or "it creates imagery" could be said about anything. Say exactly what picture or feeling it creates.
- **Using the wrong lines.** Only use the extract the question prints. Anything from elsewhere in the source won't score.
- **Writing about structure.** "The extract starts with the weather and then moves to Sam" is structure, which belongs in Question 3.
- **Wrong terms.** Calling a simile a metaphor makes your answer weaker. If you're not sure of the term, describe what the writer does in plain words instead.

Quick check

▼ 1. What three things does Question 2 suggest you could write about?

Words and phrases; language features and techniques; sentence forms.

▼ 2. How many marks is Question 2 worth, and which AO does it test?

8 marks, AO2 (the language part).

▼ 3. In "the heat crept into every room", what word class is "crept"?

A verb.

▼ 4. What's the difference between a simile and a metaphor?

A simile compares using "like" or "as"; a metaphor says one thing is another.

▼ 5. What three things does an answer need for Level 4?

Analysis of the effects of the writer's language choices, a judicious (well-chosen) range of textual detail, and sophisticated, accurate use of subject terminology.

1.3 Question 3: Structure

What the question asks

In the AQA specimen, Question 3 is worded like this:

> **The question pattern**
> You now need to think about the whole of the source.
> This text is from the opening of a novel. [The question tells you where the text comes from.]
> How has the writer structured the text to interest you as a reader?
> You could write about:
> • what the writer focuses your attention on at the beginning
> • how and why the writer changes this focus as the source develops
> • any other structural features that interest you.

- **Marks:** 8.
- **Assessment objective:** AO2, the **structure** part: how the writer has built and ordered the text, and the effect on the reader.
- **What to do:** look at the **whole** source. Explain where the writer points your attention at the start, how and why that changes, and how the ending works, using structural terms.
- **Suggested timing (a suggestion, not an AQA rule):** about 10 minutes.

How it's marked

The specimen mark scheme says structural features can work at three levels: the **whole text** (for example beginnings, endings, shifts in perspective), the **paragraph** (for example a change of topic, or how paragraphs link together) and the **sentence**, but only when a sentence helps the structure of the whole text.

Level and marks	What the mark scheme says	In plain words
Level 4: 7 to 8 marks Perceptive, detailed analysis	Analyses the effects of the writer's choice of structural features. Selects a judicious range of examples. Makes sophisticated and accurate use of subject terminology.	You explain how and why the writer built the text this way, including clever choices that aren't obvious. Your examples are well chosen. You use structural terms precisely.
Level 3: 5 to 6 marks Clear, relevant explanation	Explains clearly the effects of the writer's choice of structural features. Selects a range of relevant examples. Makes clear and accurate use of subject terminology.	You clearly explain how the focus moves and why. You use several examples and correct terms.

Level 2: 3 to 4 marks Some understanding and comment	Attempts to comment on the effect of structural features. Selects some appropriate examples. Makes some use of subject terminology, mainly appropriately.	You notice some changes in focus and try to say why. Some terms, mostly right.
Level 1: 1 to 2 marks Simple, limited comment	Offers simple comment on the effect of structural features. Selects simple references or examples. Makes simple use of subject terminology, not always appropriately.	Simple comments, like "it's in paragraphs so it's easy to read".
Level 0: no marks	No comments offered on the use of structure.	Nothing about structure.

How to do it

Step by step

1. Read the whole source and split it into a **beginning**, a **middle** and an **end**. Mark the split in the margin.
2. For each part, write a few words in the margin: **what or who** is the focus here, and **where** are we?
3. Ask **why** the writer moves the focus at each point. What does the reader learn, feel or wonder?
4. Spot one or two other features: a flashback, a one-sentence paragraph, a link between the opening and ending.
5. Write three paragraphs in order: the beginning, the shift (or shifts), the ending. In each, say what the focus is, give a short example, name the feature, and explain the effect on the reader.
6. Useful phrases: "The writer opens by focusing on…", "The focus then shifts to… in order to…", "This makes the reader wonder…", "By ending with…, the writer…".

Terms you need: structural features

Term	What it is	Why a writer might use it
Opening focus	What the writer points your attention at first	Sets the scene, the mood, or gets you curious straight away.
Shift in focus	The attention moves to a new place, person, time or idea	Introduces something new, or builds tension.
Zooming in	Moving from a wide view to a close-up, like a camera	Takes you from the setting to one character or one object, so it feels important.
Zooming out	Pulling back from a close-up to a wide view	Shows how small a character is, or shows the bigger picture.

Change of perspective	The text moves into a different character's point of view or thoughts	Lets you see events differently or understand someone better.
Flashback	The text jumps back to an earlier time	Explains the past and helps you understand what's happening now.
Foreshadowing	An early hint of something that will happen later	Builds tension and makes you want to read on to find out.
Cyclical structure	The ending returns to an idea, image or place from the opening	Gives a sense of completeness, or shows how much (or how little) has changed.
Recurring idea	An image or detail the writer keeps coming back to	Keeps something in the reader's mind all the way through.
Paragraph length	A very short or one-sentence paragraph among longer ones	Makes a moment stand out or creates a sudden change.
Sentence length (for structure)	A short sentence at a key point, such as the end	Creates a climax, a shock or a cliffhanger.
Withholding information	The writer holds back something the reader wants to know	Creates mystery and keeps you reading.
Climax and cliffhanger	The most tense point; an ending left unresolved	Leaves the reader wanting more.

Worked example

Practice source, the opening of a story

The island was tiny from the air: a green thumbprint on blue glass, with one road and a scatter of white houses.

Down on the jetty, the boat was late. A small crowd waited with shopping bags and dogs, squinting out to sea.

At the far end, apart from the others, stood a girl in a yellow raincoat. She wasn't looking at the sea. She was staring at the envelope in her hands, the one with her father's handwriting on it, the one she had promised not to open until the boat came in.

It was the same envelope she had found under her pillow the morning he left.

The horn sounded. She tore it open.

Question: This text is from the opening of a story. How has the writer structured the text to interest you as a reader?

Model answer

The writer opens with a wide view of the island "from the air", as if we're looking down from a plane. Starting so far away makes the island seem small and cut off, and because no people are mentioned, the reader is left wondering who lives there.

The focus then zooms in, first to the crowd on the jetty and then to one girl standing "apart from the others". By narrowing down like a camera, the writer picks her out as the main character and hints she's separate from everyone else. The focus then tightens again to the envelope in her hands, so a small object suddenly feels very important. The writer withholds what is inside it, which creates mystery.

Next, the one-sentence paragraph is a flashback to "the morning he left". Setting it apart on its own makes it stand out and shows the envelope is linked to her father leaving, so the reader starts to feel sympathy for her. Finally, the text ends on two short sentences: "The horn sounded. She tore it open." The boat arriving links back to the "late" boat at the start, and she breaks her promise at the very last moment, which leaves the reader on a cliffhanger, desperate to know what the letter says.

Why this would score well (Level 4): it covers the whole text in order: beginning, shifts and ending. It always explains **why** the writer made each choice and what the reader feels or wonders. It uses accurate terms (zooms in, withholds, one-sentence paragraph, flashback, cliffhanger) and short, well-chosen examples. It talks about where things are placed in the text, which is structure, and it doesn't drift into analysing single words.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Writing about language.** "The metaphor 'green thumbprint' makes the island sound small" is language analysis, which belongs in Question 2. In Question 3, talk about **where** things come in the text and why.
- **Retelling the story.** "First she is on the jetty, then she opens the envelope" just says what happens. Say why the writer put things in that order.
- **Only looking at the beginning.** The question is about the whole source. Make sure you cover the middle and the end too.
- **Empty comments about paragraphs.** "The writer uses paragraphs to make it easy to read" is a Level 1 comment. Say what a particular paragraph does.
- **"It makes the reader want to read on" with nothing else.** Say exactly what the reader wants to find out, and why.
- **Ignoring the bullet points.** They give you a plan: the beginning focus, how and why it changes, other features. Use them.
- **No terminology.** Use words like shift, zoom in, flashback, foreshadowing and cyclical, accurately.

Quick check

▼ **1. Which part of the source does Question 3 use?**

The whole of the source.

▼ 2. What are the three bullet points in the specimen question?

What the writer focuses your attention on at the beginning; how and why the writer changes this focus as the source develops; any other structural features that interest you.

▼ 3. What is a flashback?

A jump back to an earlier time in the story.

▼ 4. What is a cyclical structure?

When the ending returns to an idea, image or place from the opening.

▼ 5. According to the mark scheme, at what three levels can structure work?

Whole text (such as beginnings, endings, shifts in perspective), paragraph (such as a change of topic, or how paragraphs link), and sentence, when the sentence helps the structure of the whole text.

1.4 Question 4: Evaluation

What the question asks

In the AQA specimen, Question 4 is worded like this:

> **The question pattern**
>
> Focus this part of your answer on the second part of the source, from line [x] to the end.
> A student, having read this section of the text, said: "[a statement about the text]"
> To what extent do you agree?
> In your response, you could:
> • write about your own impressions of [for example, the characters]
> • evaluate how the writer has created these impressions
> • support your opinions with references to the text.

- **Marks:** 20, the most of any reading question.
- **Assessment objective:** AO4: evaluate texts critically and support this with appropriate textual references.
- **What to do:** decide how far you agree with the student's statement, then argue your view. Give your impressions, explain the methods the writer uses to create them (language, structure, tone), and back it all up with quotations from the right part of the source.
- **Suggested timing (a suggestion, not an AQA rule):** about 20 minutes.

How it's marked

Level and marks	What the mark scheme says	In plain words
Level 4: 16 to 20 marks Perceptive, detailed evaluation	Evaluates critically and in detail the effect(s) on the reader. Shows perceptive understanding of writer's methods. Selects a judicious range of textual detail. Develops a convincing and critical response to the focus of the statement.	You judge in detail how well the writer affects the reader. You spot clever methods that aren't obvious. Your quotations are well chosen. You argue your view of the statement convincingly, and you're willing to question it.
Level 3: 11 to 15 marks Clear, relevant evaluation	Evaluates clearly the effect(s) on the reader. Shows clear understanding of writer's methods. Selects a range of relevant textual references. Makes a clear and relevant response to the focus of the statement.	You clearly explain the effect on the reader and how the writer gets it. Several relevant quotations. You answer the statement clearly.

Level 2: 6 to 10 marks Some evaluation	Makes some evaluative comment(s) on effect(s) on the reader. Shows some understanding of writer's methods. Selects some appropriate textual reference(s). Makes some response to the focus of the statement.	You make some judgements and show some idea of how the writer works. Some quotations. Some link to the statement.
Level 1: 1 to 5 marks Simple, limited evaluation	Makes simple, limited evaluative comment(s) on effect(s) on reader. Shows limited understanding of writer's methods. Selects simple, limited textual reference(s). Makes a simple, limited response to the focus of the statement.	Simple opinions with little explanation or evidence.
Level 0: no marks	No relevant comments offered in response to the statement, no impressions, no evaluation.	Nothing relevant.

The specimen mark scheme says a good answer might evaluate how the writer uses, for example, language, structure and tone to make an impression on the reader. So in this question you can use everything you practised for Questions 2 and 3.

How to do it

Step by step

1. Box the lines you're allowed to use (usually from a line number to the end).
2. Read the statement carefully. It often has two parts, so split it and underline each part.
3. Decide how far you agree: completely, mostly, or only partly. Strong answers often agree with some of it and question some of it.
4. Find 3 or 4 short quotations that help you argue.
5. Start with a one-sentence overview that answers "to what extent".
6. Write each paragraph like this:
   - **Impression:** your view, linked to the statement.
   - **Evidence:** a short quotation.
   - **Method:** what the writer does (a technique, a word choice, a structural choice).
   - **Effect:** what the reader thinks or feels.
   - **Evaluate:** how well it works, and how far it supports the statement.
7. Finish with a short conclusion that answers the statement again.

Terms you need

Term	What it means
Evaluate	Judge how well something works, and why.
Impression	What you think of a character, place or moment.

Writer's methods	The choices the writer makes: language techniques, word choices, structure, dialogue, tone.
To what extent	How far you agree. "Completely", "mostly", "partly", "not really".
Critical	Thinking for yourself, and being willing to question the statement.
Tone	The mood or feeling of the writing, for example tense, sad, comic, hopeful.

Evaluative words that help: convincingly, effectively, vividly, cleverly, successfully, powerfully.
Phrases that help: "I agree to a large extent because...", "This is effective because...", "However, by the end I'm less convinced, as...", "The writer cleverly...".

Worked example

Practice source, the second part of a story

Mr Pask's shop smelled of glue and pencil shavings. He sat behind the counter as he always did, mending a clock with fingers that shook only slightly. When the door banged open and three boys tumbled in, laughing, he did not look up.

"You got any footballs?" one of them asked.

Mr Pask lowered the tiny screwdriver. "Second shelf. Mind the ladder." His voice was dry, like paper.

The boys found a ball, paid in coppers and left. Only then did he lift his eyes to the empty doorway, and for a moment, just a moment, the hard line of his mouth softened. He wound the clock. It began, quietly, to tick.

Question: A student said: "In this part of the story, the writer makes Mr Pask seem cold and unfriendly. You feel nobody could get close to him." To what extent do you agree?

Model evaluative paragraph

Overview: I agree with the student at the start of this section, but by the end I only partly agree, because the writer shows us there is more to Mr Pask than coldness.

At first the writer does make Mr Pask seem cold. When the boys "tumbled in, laughing", he "did not look up", and the contrast between their noisy energy and his stillness makes him seem distant, as if the boys hardly exist for him. His reply, "Second shelf. Mind the ladder.", is clipped and short, and the simile "dry, like paper" suggests there's no warmth in his voice at all. This convincingly creates the impression of a man nobody could get close to. However, the writer cleverly saves a different side of him for the end. The phrase "Only then" shows he waits until he's alone before he lets any feeling show, and the repetition in "for a moment, just a moment" slows the reader down so we notice how rare this is. When "the hard line of his mouth softened", I think the writer is suggesting he's lonely and maybe misses having young people around. So I only partly agree with the student: Mr Pask seems unfriendly on the surface, but the writer makes the reader feel sorry for him, and the final image of the clock beginning "quietly, to tick" hints that something in him is starting up again.

Why this would score well (Level 4): it answers "to what extent" straight away and comes back to it at the end. It gives clear impressions of Mr Pask, explains the writer's methods (contrast, short dialogue, simile, repetition, and saving the change for the end, which is a structural choice), and uses short, well-chosen quotations. It judges how well the methods work ("convincingly", "cleverly"), and it is critical: it agrees with part of the statement and questions the rest, with evidence for both.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **Using the wrong part of the source.** Only use the lines the question names. Quotations from the first half won't count.
- **Forgetting the statement.** Writing a good language analysis that never mentions the student's view only partly answers the question. Link every paragraph back to the statement.
- **Agreeing with no reasons.** "I agree, he is cold" is only an opinion. To evaluate, show how the writer creates the impression and how well it works.
- **Retelling the story.** Explaining what Mr Pask does, in order, isn't evaluating. Every paragraph needs a method and an effect.
- **No quotations.** AO4 asks you to support your view with references to the text. Use short quotations in every paragraph.
- **Running out of time.** This is worth 20 marks, as many as Questions 1, 2 and 3 put together. Don't spend so long on the earlier questions that you rush this one.
- **Sitting on the fence.** "Some people might agree and some might not" isn't a view. Say clearly how far **you** agree.

Quick check

▼ 1. How many marks is Question 4 worth, and which AO does it test?

20 marks, AO4: evaluate texts critically and support this with appropriate textual references.

▼ 2. Which part of the source do you use?

Only the part the question names; in the specimen, the second part of the source from a given line to the end.

▼ 3. What does "to what extent do you agree?" mean?

How far you agree with the statement: completely, mostly, partly or not really, with reasons.

▼ 4. What five things go into a strong Question 4 paragraph?

An impression linked to the statement, a short quotation, the writer's method, the effect on the reader, and an evaluation of how well it works.

▼ 5. What marks are in Level 4, and what does the top level say about the statement?

16 to 20 marks; you develop a convincing and critical response to the focus of the statement.

1.5a Question 5: Descriptive writing

What the question asks

Question 5 is the whole of Section B. AQA says the task is linked to the topic of the reading text in Section A, and you get a choice of scenario, written prompt or picture. The scenario sets out who you're writing for, why, and in what form. In the specimen paper it looks like this:

> **The question pattern**
>
> You are going to enter a creative writing competition.
> Your entry will be judged by a panel of people of your own age.
> Either: Write a description suggested by this picture: [a picture]
> Or: Write the opening part of a story about [a topic].
> (24 marks for content and organisation and 16 marks for technical accuracy) [40 marks]

- **Marks:** 40: 24 for content and organisation, 16 for technical accuracy.
- **Assessment objectives:** AO5 (content and organisation) and AO6 (technical accuracy).
- **What to do:** choose **one** task. This page covers the descriptive task: you describe a place, a person or a moment, so the reader can picture it and feel its mood. A description has very little plot; it's about painting a scene.
- **Suggested timing (a suggestion, not an AQA rule):** about 45 minutes: 5 minutes planning, 35 minutes writing, 5 minutes checking.

How it's marked

Your writing gets two marks: one for content and organisation (AO5, out of 24) and one for technical accuracy (AO6, out of 16). The same mark scheme is used whether you write a description or a story. Within each AO5 level there's an upper and lower band.

Content and organisation (AO5, 24 marks)

Level and marks	What the mark scheme looks for	In plain words
Level 4: 19 to 24 Compelling, convincing (upper 22 to 24, lower 19 to 21)	Upper: register convincing and compelling for audience; assuredly matched to purpose; extensive and ambitious vocabulary with sustained crafting of linguistic devices; varied and inventive use of structural features; compelling writing with a range of convincing and complex ideas; fluently linked paragraphs with seamlessly integrated discourse markers. Lower: register convincingly matched to audience and purpose; extensive vocabulary with conscious crafting of linguistic devices; varied and effective structural features; highly engaging writing with a range of developed complex ideas; consistently coherent paragraphs with integrated discourse markers.	Your writing grips the reader from start to finish. Your words are ambitious and your techniques are crafted all the way through. Your structure is inventive, and your paragraphs flow smoothly into each other.

Level 3: 13 to 18 Consistent, clear (upper 16 to 18, lower 13 to 15)	Upper: register consistently matched to audience and purpose; increasingly sophisticated vocabulary and phrasing, chosen for effect with a range of successful linguistic devices; effective structural features; engaging writing with a range of clear connected ideas; coherent paragraphs with integrated discourse markers. Lower: register generally matched; vocabulary clearly chosen for effect; appropriate linguistic devices; usually effective structural features; engaging, with connected ideas; usually coherent paragraphs with a range of discourse markers.	Your writing is engaging and fits the task. Your words are chosen for effect, your techniques work, and your paragraphs are clear and linked.
Level 2: 7 to 12 Some success (upper 10 to 12, lower 7 to 9)	Some sustained attempt (upper) or an attempt (lower) to match register and purpose; conscious vocabulary or beginning to vary vocabulary, with some linguistic devices; some use of, or attempts at, structural features; linked and relevant ideas; some paragraphs and discourse markers.	You're trying to suit the task and vary your words, with some techniques and some paragraphs, but it isn't always controlled.
Level 1: 1 to 6 Simple, limited (upper 4 to 6, lower 1 to 3)	Simple or occasional sense of audience and purpose; simple vocabulary; simple or limited structural features; one or two ideas, simply linked or unlinked; random paragraph structure or no paragraphs.	Simple words, few ideas, and paragraphs that are random or missing.
Level 0: no marks	No meaningful writing to assess.	Nothing to reward.

Technical accuracy (AO6, 16 marks)

Level and marks	**What the mark scheme looks for**	**In plain words**
Level 4: 13 to 16	Sentence demarcation consistently secure and consistently accurate; wide range of punctuation with a high level of accuracy; full range of appropriate sentence forms for effect; Standard English used consistently with secure control of complex grammar; high level of accuracy in spelling, including ambitious vocabulary; extensive and ambitious vocabulary.	Every sentence starts and ends in the right place. You use lots of punctuation correctly, vary your sentences on purpose, and spell even hard words correctly.

Level 3: 9 to 12	Sentence demarcation mostly secure and mostly accurate; range of punctuation mostly used with success; variety of sentence forms for effect; mostly uses Standard English with mostly controlled grammar; generally accurate spelling, including complex and irregular words; increasingly sophisticated vocabulary.	Mostly correct sentences and punctuation, a variety of sentence types, and spelling that's usually right.
Level 2: 5 to 8	Sentence demarcation mostly secure and sometimes accurate; some control of a range of punctuation; attempts a variety of sentence forms; some Standard English with some control of agreement; some accurate spelling of more complex words; varied vocabulary.	Your sentences are sometimes accurate, with some control of punctuation and some variety.
Level 1: 1 to 4	Occasional sentence demarcation; some evidence of conscious punctuation; simple range of sentence forms; occasional Standard English with limited control of agreement; accurate basic spelling; simple vocabulary.	Full stops and capitals only sometimes, simple sentences and simple words.
Level 0: no marks	Spelling, punctuation and so on are poor enough to stop the meaning being understood.	The reader can't follow it.

Sentence demarcation means starting and ending sentences correctly, with capital letters and full stops (or question or exclamation marks). **Discourse markers** are linking words and phrases like "Later", "Meanwhile", "Above them", "By midnight". AO6 makes up 20% of the marks for the whole GCSE, so accuracy is worth working on.

How to do it

Step by step

1. Read both tasks and pick the one you can picture most clearly. Note who the audience is (in the specimen, people your own age).
2. Plan for about 5 minutes (a suggestion). Use a camera plan: five paragraphs, each with one clear focus.
3. Under each paragraph in your plan, jot two or three sense details and one strong image.
4. Pick a mood and keep it all the way through, for example eerie, peaceful, tense or lonely.
5. Write, starting a new paragraph for each new focus.
6. Leave about 5 minutes (a suggestion) to check full stops, capital letters, commas and spelling.

The camera plan for a description

Paragraph	Focus
1. Wide shot	The whole scene, its weather and light, and the mood.

2. Zoom in	People or movement in the scene.
3. Close-up	One small, precise detail: an object, a face, a sound.
4. Shift in time	The same place later: an hour on, as night falls, as the weather changes.
5. Return	Back to the opening image, changed slightly (a cyclical ending).

Descriptive craft you need

- **The five senses:** sight, sound, smell, touch and taste. Most people only use sight; using smell and sound makes a description feel real.
- **Precise nouns and verbs:** "the gull wheeled" is stronger than "the bird flew around".
- **Figurative language, used carefully:** simile, metaphor, personification. A few fresh images work better than lots of tired ones.
- **Pathetic fallacy:** weather and light that match the mood.
- **Show, don't tell:** instead of "it was cold", write "breath hung in the air in small white clouds".
- **Varied sentence openings:** start with a preposition ("Above the platform..."), an adverb ("Slowly..."), an "-ing" verb ("Flickering, the sign..."), or a time phrase ("By midnight...").
- **Varied sentence lengths and forms:** a long sentence to sweep across a scene, then a short one to make a detail land; a minor sentence for effect.
- **Structural features:** zooming in and out, a shift in time, a one-sentence paragraph, a cyclical ending.
- **A range of punctuation:** commas, semicolons, colons, brackets, question marks and speech marks, used correctly.
- **One tense:** choose present or past and stick to it.

Worked example

> **Practice task**
>
> You are going to enter a creative writing competition, judged by people your own age. Write a description suggested by this picture: (a picture of a railway station late at night).

> **Model plan**
>
> 1. **Wide shot:** midnight, the last train arrives; the station "breathes out". Sounds: hiss of doors.
> 2. **Zoom in:** the passengers: a nurse in uniform, two students sharing headphones, a man holding tulips.
> 3. **Close-up:** the departure board flickering; café shutters down; smell of burnt coffee.
> 4. **Shift in time:** 1am, station empty, a cleaner mopping, rain drumming on the roof.
> 5. **Return:** the pigeon in the iron roof again; the station "breathes in", ready for morning.
>
> **Model opening paragraph**
>
> Midnight, and the station breathes out. A last train sighs against the platform, its doors folding open with a tired hiss, and a thin crowd spills onto the concrete: a nurse still in her blue uniform, two students sharing one pair of headphones, a man clutching a bunch of

> supermarket tulips as if they might escape. Above them, the departure board flickers its amber promises. Cancelled. Delayed. Cancelled. The café shutters are down, but the smell of burnt coffee lingers like a rumour. Somewhere high in the iron roof, a pigeon shifts and resettles. Nobody looks up. Everyone is too busy leaving.

Why this would score well: it opens with a minor sentence ("Midnight, and the station breathes out.") and personification that sets a tired mood straight away. It uses several senses (the "hiss" of the doors, the "amber" light, the smell of "burnt coffee"). The list of passengers after the colon shows control of punctuation and gives precise, interesting details. The sentence lengths vary on purpose: a long sentence for the crowd spilling out, then the minor sentences "Cancelled. Delayed. Cancelled." to copy the board. The pigeon is planted here so the ending can return to it, which is a cyclical structure. The plan gives every paragraph a clear focus, which helps the organisation mark, and there's no plot getting in the way of the description.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **No plan.** Without one, descriptions wander and repeat. Five minutes of planning (a suggestion) gives you five clear paragraphs.
- **No paragraphs.** The mark scheme puts "no paragraphs" at the very bottom of Level 1. Start a new paragraph each time the focus changes.
- **Run-on sentences and comma splices.** "The train arrived, the doors opened, people got off it was late" joins sentences with commas. Use full stops, or a semicolon, or a joining word like "and" or "as".
- **Turning it into a story.** If you choose the description, don't fill it with plot and dialogue. Keep it about the scene and the mood.
- **Ignoring the picture or prompt.** Your description must be clearly suggested by the task you chose.
- **Too many similes.** A pile of "like a" and "as a" phrases gets tiring. A few fresh images are better.
- **Only using sight.** Add sound, smell and touch.
- **Switching tense.** Jumping between "the rain falls" and "the rain fell" loses accuracy marks. Pick one tense.
- **Not checking.** Lost capital letters, missing full stops and misspelled common words ("there/their", "of/off") cost technical accuracy marks.

Quick check

▼ 1. How are the 40 marks for Question 5 split?

24 marks for content and organisation (AO5) and 16 marks for technical accuracy (AO6).

▼ 2. Do you answer both Question 5 tasks?

No. You choose one.

▼ **3. What's the main difference between a description and a story?**

A description paints a scene, person or moment and its mood with very little plot; a story has events and characters that move forward.

▼ **4. What is "sentence demarcation"?**

Starting and ending sentences correctly, with capital letters and full stops (or question or exclamation marks).

▼ **5. What marks are in Level 4 for content and organisation, and for technical accuracy?**

Content and organisation: 19 to 24 (upper 22 to 24, lower 19 to 21). Technical accuracy: 13 to 16.

1.5b Question 5: Narrative writing

What the question asks

Question 5 is the whole of Section B. AQA says the task is linked to the topic of the reading text in Section A, and you get a choice of scenario, written prompt or picture. In the specimen paper it looks like this:

> **The question pattern**
>
> You are going to enter a creative writing competition.
> Your entry will be judged by a panel of people of your own age.
> Either: Write a description suggested by this picture: [a picture]
> Or: Write the opening part of a story about [a topic].
> (24 marks for content and organisation and 16 marks for technical accuracy) [40 marks]

- **Marks:** 40: 24 for content and organisation, 16 for technical accuracy.
- **Assessment objectives:** AO5 (content and organisation) and AO6 (technical accuracy).
- **What to do:** choose **one** task. This page covers the narrative task: you write a story, or part of one. Read the wording closely: in the specimen it asks for "the opening part of a story", so you don't have to finish the whole story, but your writing still needs a clear shape and a strong final line.
- **Suggested timing (a suggestion, not an AQA rule):** about 45 minutes: 5 minutes planning, 35 minutes writing, 5 minutes checking.

How it's marked

Your story gets two marks: one for content and organisation (AO5, out of 24) and one for technical accuracy (AO6, out of 16). It's the same mark scheme as for a description. Within each AO5 level there's an upper and lower band.

Content and organisation (AO5, 24 marks)

Level and marks	What the mark scheme looks for	In plain words

Level 4: 19 to 24 Compelling, convincing (upper 22 to 24, lower 19 to 21)	Upper: register convincing and compelling for audience; assuredly matched to purpose; extensive and ambitious vocabulary with sustained crafting of linguistic devices; varied and inventive use of structural features; compelling writing with a range of convincing and complex ideas; fluently linked paragraphs with seamlessly integrated discourse markers. Lower: register convincingly matched to audience and purpose; extensive vocabulary with conscious crafting of linguistic devices; varied and effective structural features; highly engaging writing with a range of developed complex ideas; consistently coherent paragraphs with integrated discourse markers.	Your story grips the reader. Your words are ambitious and your techniques are crafted all the way through. Your structure is inventive, and your paragraphs flow smoothly.
Level 3: 13 to 18 Consistent, clear (upper 16 to 18, lower 13 to 15)	Upper: register consistently matched to audience and purpose; increasingly sophisticated vocabulary and phrasing, chosen for effect with a range of successful linguistic devices; effective structural features; engaging writing with a range of clear connected ideas; coherent paragraphs with integrated discourse markers. Lower: register generally matched; vocabulary clearly chosen for effect; appropriate linguistic devices; usually effective structural features; engaging, with connected ideas; usually coherent paragraphs with a range of discourse markers.	Your story is engaging and fits the task. Your words are chosen for effect, and your paragraphs are clear and linked.
Level 2: 7 to 12 Some success (upper 10 to 12, lower 7 to 9)	Some sustained attempt (upper) or an attempt (lower) to match register and purpose; conscious vocabulary or beginning to vary vocabulary, with some linguistic devices; some use of, or attempts at, structural features; linked and relevant ideas; some paragraphs and discourse markers.	You're trying to suit the task, with some techniques and some paragraphs, but it isn't always controlled.
Level 1: 1 to 6 Simple, limited (upper 4 to 6, lower 1 to 3)	Simple or occasional sense of audience and purpose; simple vocabulary; simple or limited structural features; one or two ideas, simply linked or unlinked; random paragraph structure or no paragraphs.	Simple words, few ideas, and paragraphs that are random or missing.
Level 0: no marks	No meaningful writing to assess.	Nothing to reward.

Technical accuracy (AO6, 16 marks)

Level and marks	What the mark scheme looks for	In plain words
Level 4: 13 to 16	Sentence demarcation consistently secure and consistently accurate; wide range of punctuation with a high level of accuracy; full range of appropriate sentence forms for effect; Standard English used consistently with secure control of complex grammar; high level of accuracy in spelling, including ambitious vocabulary; extensive and ambitious vocabulary.	Every sentence starts and ends in the right place. Lots of punctuation used correctly, sentences varied on purpose, hard words spelled correctly.
Level 3: 9 to 12	Sentence demarcation mostly secure and mostly accurate; range of punctuation mostly used with success; variety of sentence forms for effect; mostly uses Standard English with mostly controlled grammar; generally accurate spelling, including complex and irregular words; increasingly sophisticated vocabulary.	Mostly correct sentences and punctuation, a variety of sentence types, spelling usually right.
Level 2: 5 to 8	Sentence demarcation mostly secure and sometimes accurate; some control of a range of punctuation; attempts a variety of sentence forms; some Standard English with some control of agreement; some accurate spelling of more complex words; varied vocabulary.	Sentences sometimes accurate, some control of punctuation, some variety.
Level 1: 1 to 4	Occasional sentence demarcation; some evidence of conscious punctuation; simple range of sentence forms; occasional Standard English with limited control of agreement; accurate basic spelling; simple vocabulary.	Full stops and capitals only sometimes, simple sentences and words.
Level 0: no marks	Spelling, punctuation and so on are poor enough to stop the meaning being understood.	The reader can't follow it.

In a story, technical accuracy includes punctuating speech correctly. AO6 makes up 20% of the marks for the whole GCSE.

How to do it

Step by step

1. Read both tasks. Check exactly what the story task asks for (for example "the opening part of a story", or a story about a particular topic) and who the audience is.
2. Plan for about 5 minutes (a suggestion). Keep it small: one or two main characters, one main setting, a short stretch of time.

3. Use a five-part plan (below) and decide your final line before you start writing.
4. Choose first person ("I") or third person ("she") and one tense, and stick to them.
5. Write, starting a new paragraph for a new time, place, topic or speaker.
6. Leave about 5 minutes (a suggestion) to check full stops, capitals, speech punctuation and spelling.

A five-part story plan

Part	What happens
1. Hook	Start in the middle of something, with a striking detail, a line of speech or a question.
2. Build	Tell the reader a bit more about the character and setting; a flashback can fit here.
3. Problem	Something goes wrong, or a choice has to be made. Tension rises.
4. Climax	The most tense or emotional moment.
5. Ending	A resolution, a twist, a cliffhanger, or a return to the opening (cyclical).

Narrative craft you need

- **A strong hook:** begin in the middle of the action, not with waking up or the alarm clock.
- **A small cast:** one or two characters you can bring to life in detail.
- **Show, don't tell:** instead of "she was nervous", write "she checked the door handle three times".
- **Dialogue, used sparingly:** a few lines that reveal character or build tension. New speaker, new line.
- **Narrative perspective:** first person feels close and personal; third person lets you see more. Don't switch by accident.
- **Structural features:** a flashback, foreshadowing (an early hint), a one-sentence paragraph for a key moment, a cyclical ending.
- **Setting and mood:** use descriptive skills too: senses, precise verbs, pathetic fallacy.
- **Varied sentences:** longer sentences for build-up, short ones for shocks; varied openings.
- **Discourse markers to move time on:** "Later that night", "By the time", "Downstairs", "Only then".
- **A range of punctuation:** commas, colons, semicolons, question marks and correctly punctuated speech.

Worked example

> **Practice task**
>
> You are going to enter a creative writing competition, judged by people your own age. Write the opening part of a story about someone who finds something they were not meant to find.

Model plan

1. **Hook:** Nadia finds a key taped under a drawer in Gran's bedroom, a week after the funeral. The label says "DON'T, NADIA".
2. **Build:** flashback to Gran saying "some doors are best left shut", which she thought was a joke. Foreshadowing: the locked attic.
3. **Problem:** she climbs to the attic while Mum is on the phone; the key fits a tin box.
4. **Climax:** inside are letters to Gran from a sister nobody in the family knew existed.
5. **Ending:** Nadia hears Mum on the stairs and must decide whether to hide the letters. Final line returns to the key, now in her pocket (cyclical).

Model opening paragraph

The key was taped to the underside of the bottom drawer, and Nadia only found it because the drawer jammed. She knelt on Gran's bedroom carpet, in a room that still smelled of lavender and cough sweets, and peeled the brittle tape away with her thumbnail. It was small and brass, with a paper label tied on by a thread. Two words, in Gran's neat, sloping capitals: DON'T, NADIA. She sat back on her heels. Downstairs, Mum was on the phone to the solicitor again, her voice rising and falling like a tide. Nadia looked at the key for a long time. Then she put it in her pocket.

Why this would score well: it starts in the middle of the action with an intriguing object, so the reader is hooked from the first sentence. The detail of the smell ("lavender and cough sweets") quietly shows that Gran has died, without saying it. The label uses her name, which builds mystery and tension. The minor sentence "Two words, in Gran's neat, sloping capitals" and the colon before "DON'T, NADIA" show control of punctuation. "Downstairs" is a discourse marker that shifts the focus and hints at family stress. The paragraph ends on two short sentences and a decision, which sets up the rest of the story. The plan keeps the story small (one main character, one house, one afternoon) with a clear shape, foreshadowing and a cyclical ending, which helps the organisation mark.

Exam mistakes that lose marks

- **No plan.** Stories without a plan often run out of time before the ending, or wander. Plan your five parts and your last line first.
- **No paragraphs.** The mark scheme puts "no paragraphs" at the bottom of Level 1. New paragraph for a new time, place, topic or speaker.
- **Run-on sentences and comma splices.** "Nadia found the key, she put it in her pocket" joins two sentences with a comma. Use a full stop, a semicolon, or a joining word: "Nadia found the key and put it in her pocket."
- **Too much plot.** Car chases, five characters and three locations in 35 minutes leave no room for description or detail. Keep it small and do it well.
- **Too much dialogue.** Pages of speech with no description read like a text conversation. Use a few lines for effect.
- **Weak endings.** "And then I woke up and it was all a dream" undoes your whole story. Plan an ending that links back or leaves a question.

- **Switching tense or person.** Moving between "I" and "she", or past and present, loses marks. Choose and stick to it.
- **Not doing what the task asks.** If it asks for the opening part of a story about a topic, your writing must clearly be that.
- **Speech punctuation errors.** Put the spoken words and their punctuation inside the speech marks: "Mind the ladder," he said.

Quick check

▼ 1. When should you start a new paragraph in a story?

For a new time, place, topic or speaker.

▼ 2. Fix this comma splice: "The door creaked, Nadia froze."

"The door creaked. Nadia froze." (or "The door creaked; Nadia froze." or "The door creaked and Nadia froze.")

▼ 3. What is foreshadowing?

An early hint of something that will happen later in the story.

▼ 4. Is the mark scheme different for a story and a description?

No. Both are marked on content and organisation (AO5, 24 marks) and technical accuracy (AO6, 16 marks).

▼ 5. What marks are in Level 3 for content and organisation, and for technical accuracy?

Content and organisation: 13 to 18 (upper 16 to 18, lower 13 to 15). Technical accuracy: 9 to 12.